

# Optimal lattices for a three-body power-law energy: steep-decay limits, computer-assisted proofs and the minima of the modular graph functions $C_{s,s,s}$

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**Abstract** We study which Bravais lattice of fixed density minimises the three-body energy  $T_v(\Lambda) = \sum'_{x,y \in \Lambda} (|x||y||x-y|)^{-v}$ , the sum over all lattice triangles through the origin of the product of their side lengths to the power  $-v$ . In two dimensions  $T_{2s}$  coincides, up to a factor, with the two-loop modular graph function  $C_{s,s,s}(\tau)$ . We prove that in the steep-decay limit  $v \rightarrow \infty$  the minimisers converge to the rectangular lattice with aspect ratio  $\sqrt{(\sqrt{17}-1)/2}$  in  $d=2$ , by solving exactly the associated max–min problem for the smallest triangle product, and to the body-centred cubic lattice in  $d=3$ , by a computer-assisted argument. For finite exponents we give computer-assisted proofs, carried out in rigorous interval arithmetic, that  $C_{2,2,2}$ ,  $C_{3,3,3}$  and  $C_{4,4,4}$  attain their minimum only at the square point  $\tau = i$  (whereas  $C_{1,1,1}$  is minimal at the hexagonal point), that the square lattice is the unique minimiser also for  $v=5, 7$ , that the hexagonal lattice is the unique minimiser for  $v=3.5$ , that the hexagonal and square energies cross in  $(3.918364, 3.918366)$ , and that the square lattice loses local minimality at some  $v_2 \in (8.604, 8.608)$ . The proofs rest on a majorant series that bounds all Taylor coefficients of every summand uniformly in the lattice vectors; the elementary planar results are also formalised in Lean 4. Numerically, the planar minimiser switches discontinuously from hexagonal to square at  $v^* \approx 3.91836$  and bifurcates continuously from square to rectangular at  $v_2$ . In three dimensions BCC is the best lattice found for all tested exponents  $3.2 \leq v \leq 12$ , FCC loses local stability at  $v_c = 3.7521 \pm 0.0001$ , and hcp with  $c/a \in [1.45, 1.85]$  is never optimal at the tested exponents.

**Keywords** Lattice energy minimisation · Three-body interactions · Modular graph functions · Computer-assisted proof · Max–min problems · Crystallisation

## 1 Introduction

Which periodic arrangement of points minimises a given interaction energy is one of the classical questions linking number theory, geometry and the physics of crystals. For *pair* interactions a great deal is known: for completely monotone functions of the squared distance the hexagonal lattice is optimal in the plane among all lattices of fixed density [1, 2, 3, 4, 5], universal optimality has been established for  $E_8$  and the Leech lattice [6], and phase transitions between optimal lattices have been classified for many two-term and ratio-type pair energies [7, 8, 9]. In three dimensions the optimality of the face-centred cubic lattice for Epstein zeta func-

tions (the Sarnak–Strömbergsson conjecture) has recently been claimed [10]. We refer to [18] for a survey of the crystallisation problem.

Much less is known for genuine *many-body* energies. The simplest one is the product-form three-body power law

$$T_v(\Lambda) = \sum_{\substack{x,y \in \Lambda \setminus \{0\} \\ x \neq y}} (|x||y||x-y|)^{-v}, \quad (1)$$

which converges for  $v > 2d/3$ . At  $v=3$  it is the radial part of the Axilrod–Teller–Muto (ATM) triple-dipole energy; under the name *three-body zeta function* it was introduced and evaluated for selected lattices and along the Bain path in [11], and efficient algorithms for such many-body lattice sums were developed in [12, 13]. We stress that (1) is a model energy: physical three-body dispersion carries an angular factor and always comes with pair terms. Three-body terms do appear in rigorous crystallisation results for finite particle systems, but in a different form: as *angular* potentials that favour prescribed bond angles, in the square lattice [19, 20], in general stratified settings [21, 22] and for the FCC lattice [23]; many-body embedded-atom models were treated in [24]. These works minimise over configurations with short-range interactions and do not concern the long-range power-law sum (1) over lattices. Our motivation is mathematical. In  $d=2$ , the energy  $T_{2s}$  is (up to normalisation) the two-loop *modular graph function*  $C_{s,s,s}(\tau)$  from the low-energy expansion of genus-one string amplitudes [15]; its minimum over the fundamental domain appears not to have been studied.

Two remarks delimit the content. First,  $T_v$  is invariant under isometries, so the hexagonal and the square lattice (the elliptic fixed points  $\rho = e^{i\pi/3}$  and  $i$  of the modular group) are always critical points [16]. The substance of the results below is *global* minimality and the location of the switches between minimisers. Second, the reduction of a steep-decay limit to a packing-type problem is standard for pair energies [7]; here it leads to a new max–min problem for triangles, related in spirit to three-point packing problems on the sphere [17].

**Summary of results.** Fig. 1 summarises the planar picture.

- Theorem 1 solves exactly the planar max–min problem for the smallest triangle product; Theorem 2 deduces that minimisers of  $T_v$  converge to a rectangular lattice with aspect ratio  $y_\infty = \sqrt{(\sqrt{17}-1)/2}$ .

- Theorem 3 (computer-assisted) shows that in  $d = 3$  the body-centred cubic (BCC) lattice is the unique maximiser of the smallest triangle product; minimisers of  $T_V$  converge to BCC.
- Theorem 4 (computer-assisted, rigorous interval arithmetic) establishes the minimiser for the finite exponents  $v \in \{3.5, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8\}$ ; in particular  $C_{2,2,2}$ ,  $C_{3,3,3}$ ,  $C_{4,4,4}$  are minimal only at  $\tau = i$ . It also encloses the crossing  $v^*$  and the loss of stability  $v_2$  of the square lattice.
- Sections 6 and 7 give the numerical phase diagrams with error bars, including hcp, unequal exponents and mixed pair plus three-body energies.

## 2 Setting and the modular graph function

Throughout, lattices are Bravais lattices of unit covolume, considered up to isometry. For three pairwise distinct points  $p, q, r$  put  $\pi(p, q, r) = |p - q||q - r||r - p|$ , and let

$$P(\Lambda) = \min\{\pi(p, q, r) : p, q, r \in \Lambda \text{ pairwise distinct}\},$$

the smallest triangle product; collinear triples are admitted. Every triple can be translated to contain the origin, hence

$$T_V(\Lambda) \geq P(\Lambda)^{-v}. \quad (2)$$

In  $d = 2$  we write  $\Lambda_\tau = (\mathbb{Z} + \tau\mathbb{Z})/\sqrt{\text{Im } \tau}$  with  $\tau = x + iy$  in the fundamental domain. The modular graph function of [15] is  $C_{a,b,c}(\tau) = \sum_{p_1+p_2+p_3=0, p_i \neq 0} \prod_i (\text{Im } \tau / \pi |p_i|^2)^{a_i}$ ,  $p_i \in \mathbb{Z} + \tau\mathbb{Z}$ , and a direct comparison gives

$$C_{s,s,s}(\tau) = \pi^{-3s} T_{2s}(\Lambda_\tau). \quad (3)$$

At  $s = 1$ , Zagier's identity  $C_{1,1,1} = E_3 + \zeta(3)$  and the minimality of the Epstein zeta function at  $\rho$  [1, 2, 3, 4] show that  $C_{1,1,1}$  is minimal only at  $\rho$ . We verified (3) numerically, and the identities  $C_{1,1,1} = E_3 + \zeta(3)$  and  $C_{2,2,1} = \frac{2}{3}E_5 + \zeta(5)/30$  to relative accuracy  $10^{-14}$  and  $10^{-15}$  at five values of  $\tau$  (Appendix A).

## 3 The planar steep-decay limit

Let  $a_* = ((1 + \sqrt{17})/8)^{1/4} \approx 0.894563$ , so that  $4a_*^8 = a_*^4 + 1$ , and put

$$P_* = 2a_*^3 = \sqrt{a_*^2 + a_*^{-2}} \approx 1.431734, \quad \Lambda_* = a_*\mathbb{Z} \times a_*^{-1}\mathbb{Z}.$$

The aspect ratio of  $\Lambda_*$  is  $y_\infty = a_*^{-2} = \sqrt{(\sqrt{17} - 1)/2} \approx 1.249621$ .

**Theorem 1.** *For every lattice  $\Lambda \subset \mathbb{R}^2$  of unit covolume,  $P(\Lambda) \leq P_*$ , with equality if and only if  $\Lambda$  is isometric to  $\Lambda_*$ .*

**Lemma 1.** *After a rotation and a reflection,  $\Lambda$  has a basis  $u = (a, 0)$ ,  $v = (p, a^{-1})$  with  $a = \lambda_1(\Lambda)$ ,  $0 \leq p \leq a/2$  and  $|v| \geq a$ ; moreover  $a^4 \leq 4/3$ .*

*Proof.* Lagrange–Gauss reduction; the bound is Hermite's constant  $\gamma_2 = 2/\sqrt{3}$ .  $\square$

**Lemma 2.** *In the notation of Lemma 1,  $P(\Lambda) \leq G(a) := \min\{2a^3, \sqrt{a^2 + a^{-2}}\}$ , and  $\pi(0, u, v) \leq \sqrt{a^2 + a^{-2}}$  with equality if and only if  $p = 0$ .*

*Proof.* The collinear triple  $(0, u, 2u)$  gives  $2a^3$ . For  $(0, u, v)$  we have  $\pi^2 = a^2(p^2 + k)((a - p)^2 + k)$  with  $k = a^{-2}$ . With  $m = p(a - p) \in [0, a^2/4]$  and  $p^2 + (a - p)^2 = a^2 - 2m$ ,

$$(p^2 + k)((a - p)^2 + k) = (ka^2 + k^2) + m(m - 2k).$$

Since  $a^4 < 8$ ,  $m \leq a^2/4 < 2k$ , so the last term is  $\leq 0$ , with equality iff  $m = 0$ , i.e.  $p = 0$ . Hence  $\pi^2 \leq a^2(ka^2 + k^2) = a^2 + a^{-2}$ .  $\square$

**Lemma 3.** *For  $0 < a \leq (4/3)^{1/4}$ ,  $G(a) \leq P_*$  with equality iff  $a = a_*$ .*

*Proof.* For  $a \leq a_*$ ,  $G(a) \leq 2a^3 \leq 2a_*^3$ . The function  $g(a) = a^2 + a^{-2}$  decreases on  $(0, 1]$  and increases on  $[1, \infty)$ . For  $a_* < a \leq 1$ ,  $G(a) \leq \sqrt{g(a)} < \sqrt{g(a_*)} = P_*$ . For  $1 \leq a \leq (4/3)^{1/4}$ ,  $g(a) \leq \frac{2}{\sqrt{3}} + \frac{\sqrt{3}}{2} = \frac{7}{2\sqrt{3}}$  and  $(\frac{7}{2\sqrt{3}})^2 = \frac{49}{12} < 16(\frac{1+\sqrt{17}}{8})^3 = P_*^4$ .  $\square$

**Lemma 4.**  $P(\Lambda_*) = P_*$ .

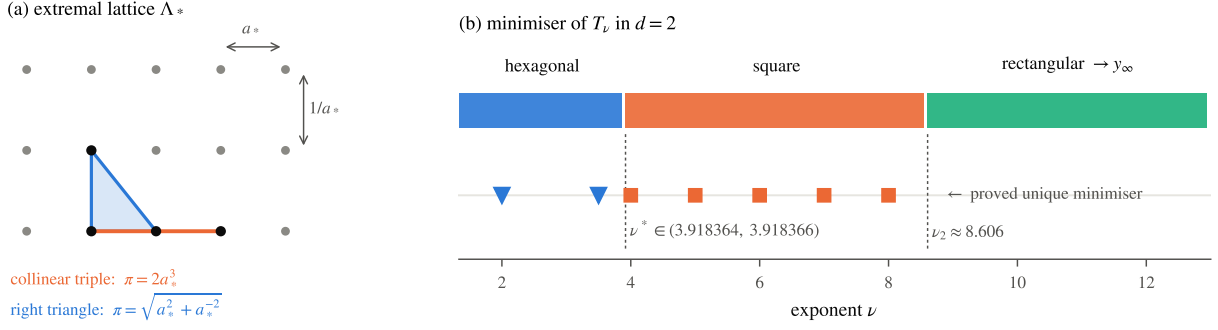
*Proof.* The triples in Fig. 1(a) give  $P(\Lambda_*) \leq P_*$ . Collinear triples lie on a lattice line with spacing  $s \geq a_*$  and have  $\pi = s^3(k - j)(l - k)(l - j) \geq 2s^3 \geq P_*$ . A non-collinear lattice triangle has area  $\geq \frac{1}{2}$ ; with side lengths  $d_1 \leq d_2 \leq d_3$  and  $\gamma$  the angle between the two shorter sides,  $d_1 d_2 \geq d_1 d_2 \sin \gamma \geq 1$ , hence  $\pi \geq d_3$ . The only vectors of  $\Lambda_*$  shorter than  $D = \sqrt{a_*^2 + a_*^{-2}}$  are  $\pm u, \pm v$  with  $u = (a_*, 0)$ ,  $v = (0, a_*^{-1})$ : for  $(ma_*, na_*^{-1})$  with  $n \neq 0$  one gets  $m = 0$  and  $n^2 < 1 + a_*^4 < 2$ , and for  $n = 0$ ,  $m^2 < 1 + y_\infty^2 < 4$ . They span two directions, whereas the three sides of a triangle are pairwise linearly independent. Thus  $d_3 \geq D = P_*$ .  $\square$

*Proof of Theorem 1.* Lemmas 1–3 give  $P(\Lambda) \leq G(a) \leq P_*$ . Equality forces  $a = a_*$  and  $\pi(0, u, v) \geq P_* = \sqrt{a_*^2 + a_*^{-2}}$ , hence  $p = 0$  by Lemma 2, i.e.  $\Lambda = \Lambda_*$ . The converse is Lemma 4.  $\square$

**Theorem 2.** *For every  $v > 4/3$ ,  $T_V$  attains its minimum among planar lattices of unit covolume. If  $\Lambda_v$  is any minimiser, then  $\Lambda_v \rightarrow \Lambda_*$  up to isometries as  $v \rightarrow \infty$ , and  $(\min T_V)^{1/v} \rightarrow 1/P_*$ . Equivalently, minimisers  $\tau_s$  of  $C_{s,s,s}$  on the fundamental domain satisfy  $\tau_s \rightarrow iy_\infty$  as  $s \rightarrow \infty$ .*

*Proof.*  $P$  is continuous and  $P(\Lambda) \leq 2\lambda_1(\Lambda)^3$ ;  $T_V$  is lower semicontinuous as a sum of non-negative continuous functions. By (2), sublevel sets of  $T_V$  lie in  $\{\lambda_1 \geq \varepsilon\}$ , compact by Mahler's criterion, so minimisers exist. Every term of  $T_V(\Lambda_*)$  has  $\pi \geq P_*$ , whence  $T_V(\Lambda_*) \leq CP_*^{-v}$  for  $v \geq v_0$  with  $C = T_{v_0}(\Lambda_*)P_*^{v_0}$ . With (2),  $P(\Lambda_v)^{-v} \leq T_V(\Lambda_v) \leq T_V(\Lambda_*) \leq CP_*^{-v}$ , so  $P_* \geq P(\Lambda_v) \geq C^{-1/v}P_* \rightarrow P_*$ . The  $\Lambda_v$  lie in a compact set; every limit point has  $P = P_*$  and is  $\Lambda_*$  by Theorem 1. The statement for  $C_{s,s,s}$  follows from (3).  $\square$

The numerical minimisers for finite  $v$  (Sect. 6) approach  $\Lambda_*$  monotonically: the optimal aspect ratio is 1.056, 1.100, 1.141, 1.170, 1.194 and 1.215 at  $v = 9, 10, 12, 15, 20, 30$ . A random test on  $2 \cdot 10^4$  lattices confirmed the bound of Lemma 2, and a grid maximisation of  $P$  located the maximum at  $\tau \approx 1.2475i$ .



**Fig. 1** (a) The extremal lattice  $\Lambda_*$  of Theorem 1: the collinear triple (red) and the right triangle (blue) have the same side-length product  $P_*$ . (b) Minimiser of  $T_v$  in  $d=2$ . Shaded regions: numerical phase diagram (Sect. 6); symbols: exponents at which the minimiser is established rigorously ( $\nu=2$  classical, the others by Theorem 4). For  $\nu \rightarrow \infty$  the minimiser converges to  $\Lambda_*$  (Theorem 2).

*Formal verification.* Both mathematical parts of the proof of Theorem 1 are formalised in Lean 4 with Mathlib. The first is the upper bound  $\min\{4a^6, \Phi(a, p)\} \leq P_*^2$  for reduced bases, with  $\Phi(a, p) = \pi(0, u, v)^2$ , together with its equality case  $a = a_*$ ,  $p = 0$  (Lemmas 2 and 3). The second is the lower bound for all lattice triangles of the rectangular lattices  $\sqrt{s}\mathbb{Z} \times \mathbb{Z}/\sqrt{s}$  with  $1/3 < s^2 < 1$  (Lemma 4). The formalisation contains no `sorry`, and `#print axioms` reports only the standard axioms (`propext`, `Classical.choice`, `Quot.sound`). Not formalised are the classical facts used in Lemma 1 (existence of a reduced basis, Hermite's bound), the translation invariance of  $\pi$ , and the compactness argument of Theorem 2.

#### 4 Three dimensions

In  $d=3$  the energy converges for  $\nu > 2$ . For BCC of unit covolume  $P(\text{BCC}) = 3/2$ , attained by isosceles triangles with two nearest-neighbour sides and one second-neighbour side; in contrast  $P(\text{FCC}) = P(\text{SC}) = P(\text{hcp}) = \sqrt{2}$ .

**Theorem 3** (computer-assisted). *For every lattice  $\Lambda \subset \mathbb{R}^3$  of unit covolume,  $P(\Lambda) \leq 3/2$ , with equality iff  $\Lambda$  is isometric to BCC. Consequently, for  $\nu > 2$  minimisers of  $T_\nu$  exist and converge to BCC as  $\nu \rightarrow \infty$ , with  $(\min T_\nu)^{1/\nu} \rightarrow 2/3$ .*

Let  $G = B^T B$  be the Gram matrix of a basis, normalised by  $G_{11} = \lambda_1^2 = 1$ , and  $Q(G) = P(\Lambda)/\sqrt{\det G}$  (scale invariant). The remaining entries  $q = (g_{22}, g_{33}, g_{12}, g_{13}, g_{23})$  are the parameters.

**Lemma 5.** *Every lattice has, up to isometry and scaling, a Gram matrix in the region  $\mathcal{R}$  given by  $1 \leq g_{22} \leq g_{33}$ ,  $0 \leq g_{12}, g_{13} \leq \frac{1}{2}$ ,  $|g_{23}| \leq g_{22}/2$  and  $1 + g_{22} + 2(\epsilon_1 \epsilon_2 g_{12} + \epsilon_1 g_{13} + \epsilon_2 g_{23}) \geq 0$  for  $\epsilon_i = \pm 1$ . On  $\mathcal{R}$ ,  $\det G \geq g_{22}g_{33}/4$ ; hence  $Q < 3/2$  whenever  $g_{22}g_{33} > 64/9$ .*

*Proof.* Take a Minkowski-reduced basis and flip the signs of  $b_2, b_3$ . The triangle  $(0, b_1, b_2)$  is acute, so the covering radius of  $L_2 = \mathbb{Z}b_1 + \mathbb{Z}b_2$  is its circumradius  $\rho$ , with  $\rho^2 = g_{22}|b_2 - b_1|^2/(4(g_{22} - g_{12}^2)) \leq (1 + g_{22})/3$ . Minkowski reduction places the projection of  $b_3$  onto the plane of  $L_2$  in its Voronoi cell, so the height  $h$  of  $b_3$  satisfies  $h^2 \geq g_{33} - \rho^2 \geq g_{33}/3$ , and  $\det G = (g_{22} - g_{12}^2)h^2 \geq g_{22}g_{33}/4$ . The collinear triple  $(0, b_1, 2b_1)$  gives  $Q \leq 2/\sqrt{\det G}$ .  $\square$

Within  $\mathcal{R}$ , BCC has the single representative  $q_0 = (1, 1, \frac{1}{3}, \frac{1}{3}, -\frac{1}{3})$ , found by enumerating unimodular changes of basis.

**Lemma 6** (local lemma). *For a triangle  $t = (0, m, n)$  put  $f_t(q) = \sqrt{\ell_m \ell_n \ell_{m-n}}/\det G$  with  $\ell_v = v^T G v$ . At  $q_0$  exactly 36 triangles are active,  $f_t(q_0) = 3/2$ , and their gradients take 6 distinct values whose convex hull contains the origin at distance  $c$  from its boundary, where  $c^2 = 27/1400$  exactly ( $c = 0.138873\dots$ ; computed in rational arithmetic). On  $q_0 + [-r, r]^5$  with  $r = 0.007$ , interval arithmetic gives  $\|\nabla^2 f_t\|_F \leq M = 14.92$  for all active  $t$ . Hence  $\min_t f_t(q_0 + \delta) \leq \frac{3}{2} - c|\delta| + \frac{M}{2}|\delta|^2 < \frac{3}{2}$  for  $0 < |\delta| \leq \sqrt{5}r = 0.0157 < 2c/M = 0.0186$ .*

*Branch and bound.* On a box  $B$  of parameters each  $\ell_v$  is linear in  $q$  and  $\det G$  is a cubic polynomial, so  $Q \leq \min_{t \in S} (\prod \max_B \ell)^{1/2} (\min_B \det G)^{-1/2}$  for any set  $S$  of candidate triangles; we use all  $(0, m, n)$  with  $m, n \in \{-1, 0, 1\}^3$  and the collinear  $(0, m, 2m)$ . Starting from the compact box  $[1, \frac{8}{3}] \times [1, \frac{64}{9}] \times [0, \frac{1}{2}]^2 \times [-\frac{4}{3}, \frac{4}{3}]$ , boxes are discarded when they violate a constraint of  $\mathcal{R}$ , lie in  $q_0 + [-r, r]^5$ , or have upper bound  $< 3/2$ , and bisected otherwise. All bounds are evaluated with directed (outward) rounding, so that each computed upper bound is a true upper bound (Appendix B). The run terminates after 9868069 boxes with every box certified. With Lemmas 5 and 6 this proves  $Q \leq 3/2$  on  $\mathcal{R}$  with equality only at  $q_0$ . The convergence statement follows as in Theorem 2.

#### 5 Finite exponents: computer-assisted proofs

**Theorem 4** (computer-assisted). *Among planar lattices of unit covolume, the square lattice is the unique minimiser of  $T_\nu$  for  $\nu \in \{4, 5, 6, 7, 8\}$ , and the hexagonal lattice is the unique minimiser for  $\nu = 3.5$ . In particular  $C_{2,2,2}$ ,  $C_{3,3,3}$  and  $C_{4,4,4}$  attain their minimum on the fundamental domain only at  $\tau = i$ . Moreover  $T_\nu(\mathbb{Z}^2) - T_\nu(\Lambda_\rho)$  changes sign in  $(3.918364, 3.918366)$ , and the second derivative of  $y \mapsto T_\nu(\Lambda_{iy})$  at  $y = 1$  changes sign in  $(8.604, 8.608)$ ; in particular the square lattice is not a local minimiser for  $\nu = 8.608$ .*

Together with the case  $s = 1$  and Theorem 2, the minimiser of  $C_{s,s,s}$  is thus  $\rho$  for  $s = 1$ ,  $i$  for  $s = 2, 3, 4$ , and tends to  $iy_\infty$  as  $s \rightarrow \infty$ .

**Table 1** Data of the rigorous computer-assisted proofs of Theorem 4.

| $v$ | point  | $T_v(\tau_0)$ (enclosure)      | $c_{20} \geq$ | $r_{\text{loc}}$ | boxes |
|-----|--------|--------------------------------|---------------|------------------|-------|
| 3.5 | $\rho$ | [9.77228723809, 9.77246454156] | 2.127         | 0.0018           | 373   |
| 4   | $i$    | [7.58266977279, 7.58267002399] | 0.4368        | 0.0031           | 531   |
| 5   | $i$    | [4.83802684659, 4.83802684684] | 2.5821        | 0.0069           | 303   |
| 6   | $i$    | [3.24997431242, 3.24997431246] | 4.2719        | 0.0076           | 307   |
| 7   | $i$    | [2.23344617477, 2.23344617480] | 5.3445        | 0.0050           | 323   |
| 8   | $i$    | [1.55240121256, 1.55240121259] | 5.8308        | 0.0026           | 385   |

*A universal majorant.* For  $v = (m, n)$  and  $\tau = x + iy$  let  $\ell_v = |m + n\tau|^2/y$ , so that  $T_v = \sum \prod_{\text{sides}} \ell^{-s}$  with  $s = v/2$ . Around  $(x_0, y_0)$  put  $A = a/y_0$ ,  $B = b/y_0$ . A short computation gives

$$\frac{\ell_v(x_0 + a, y_0 + b)}{\ell_v(x_0, y_0)} = 1 + \frac{(2\alpha^2 - 1)B + 2\alpha\beta A + \alpha^2(A^2 + B^2)}{1 + B},$$

where  $\alpha^2 + \beta^2 = 1$  depend on  $v$ . Coefficientwise, therefore,  $\ell/\ell_0 - 1 \ll \hat{\varepsilon} := (A + B + A^2 + B^2)/(1 - B)$ , and every triangle term  $t$  satisfies  $t/t_0 \ll (1 - \hat{\varepsilon})^{-3s}$ , uniformly in the lattice vectors. Consequently all Taylor coefficients of  $T_v$  at  $\tau_0$  are bounded by  $T_v(\tau_0)$  times the coefficients  $\hat{G}_{ij}$  of  $(1 - \hat{\varepsilon})^{-3s}$ . This yields explicit Taylor remainders and explicit bounds for the terms omitted by a finite truncation.

*Proof structure.* Let  $\tau_0 \in \{i, \rho\}$  be the candidate. (i) For  $y > Y_0$  the collinear triples along the vector 1 give  $T_v(\tau) \geq y^{3s} \sum_{j \neq k} (|j||k||j - k|)^{-2s} > T_v(\tau_0)$ . (ii) Local lemma: the reflections fixing  $\tau_0$  ( $x \mapsto -x$  and  $\tau \mapsto 1/\bar{\tau}$  at  $i$ ;  $x \mapsto 1 - x$  and the order-three rotation at  $\rho$ ) force  $c_{10} = c_{01} = c_{11} = c_{30} = c_{12} = 0$  in the Taylor expansion. With rigorous enclosures of  $c_{20}, c_{02}, c_{21}, c_{03}$  and the majorant remainder,  $T(\tau_0 + \delta) - T(\tau_0) \geq A^2(c_{20} - |c_{21}|r - \rho) + B^2(c_{02} - |c_{03}|r - \rho) > 0$  for  $0 < \max(|A|, |B|) \leq r_{\text{loc}}$ , where  $\rho = T \sum_{i+j \geq 4} \hat{G}_{ij} r^{i+j-2}$ . (iii) The rest of  $[0, \frac{1}{2}] \times [0.8, Y_0]$  is covered by boxes on which the second-order Taylor polynomial at the centre, with rigorous coefficient enclosures, minus the majorant remainder exceeds an upper bound for  $T(\tau_0)$ . All coefficients are enclosed rigorously: the summands are evaluated in outward-rounded interval arithmetic (powers in Arb [25]), the cube-truncated sums ( $R = 40$ ) by direct, non-FFT convolution with a Higham-type bound for the accumulated rounding error, and the omitted terms by an explicit tail bound (Appendix B). All comparisons are done on the resulting enclosures. Table 1 lists the data.

The crossing statement uses the same enclosures at  $R = 100$  and gives  $T_v(\mathbb{Z}^2) - T_v(\Lambda_\rho) \in [2.31, 2.90] \cdot 10^{-7}$  at  $v = 3.918364$  and  $\in [-3.46, -2.87] \cdot 10^{-7}$  at  $v = 3.918366$ . For  $v_2$ , the coefficient  $c_{02}$  at  $\tau = i$ , i.e. half the second  $B$ -derivative, is enclosed in  $[1.1544, 1.1545] \cdot 10^{-3}$  at  $v = 8.604$  and in  $[-1.3452, -1.3451] \cdot 10^{-3}$  at  $v = 8.608$ , while  $c_{20} \approx 5.89 > 0$  at both exponents.

**Remark 1** (status of the computer-assisted parts). All computer-assisted statements (Theorems 3 and 4) are proved with rigorous error control. Every floating-point operation that enters a certificate is either rounded outward (interval arithmetic with `nextafter`, relying on correctly rounded IEEE-754  $+$ ,  $-$ ,  $\times$ ,  $\div$ ,  $\sqrt{\phantom{x}}$ ) or evaluated in the ball arithmetic of Arb [25]; large sums are computed by direct convolution

in double precision with an a-priori bound of the accumulated rounding error of the form  $\gamma_n \sum |a_i| |b_j|$ ,  $\gamma_n = nu/(1 - nu)$  [26]. The trusted base therefore consists of IEEE-754 double arithmetic, the direct convolution routine of SciPy, Arb (via python-flint), and the short Python drivers. The code, the logs and the certificates are publicly available (see Declarations). As independent sanity checks, the three-dimensional box bounds were compared with brute-force values at 1200 random points, and the provers fail, as they must, when asked to certify false statements such as  $Q < 1.49$ .

The same method did not succeed for the hexagonal lattice at  $v = 3$ . Close to  $v = d$  the truncation tail decays only like  $R^{2-2v}$  with a large constant, and at  $R = 40$  the error exceeds the energy gap next to  $\rho$ .

*Continua of exponents.* Theorem 4 covers individual exponents. Extending it to an interval such as  $v \in [4, 8]$  requires enclosures that are uniform in  $v$ ; the majorant is monotone in  $s$ , and  $\partial_v$  of every summand is bounded by log of the side-length product times the summand, so a covering of  $[4, 8]$  by  $v$ -intervals is possible in principle. With the present implementation, where one exponent costs 20–40 minutes, a covering fine enough near  $v = 4$  (where  $c_{20}$  is small) would need of the order of  $10^2$  exponent intervals and several CPU days, so we leave it for future work.

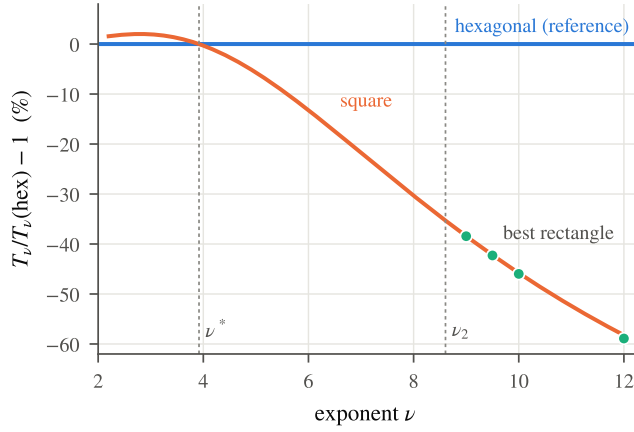
## 6 Numerical phase diagram

The numerical results use an independent reference summation, described in Appendix A. It agrees with the library of [13] to better than  $2 \cdot 10^{-10}$  relative in 55 test cases and reproduces the published values of [11] at  $v = 3$ .

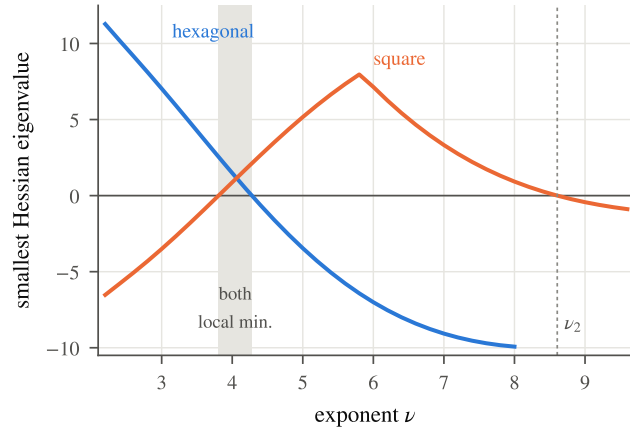
**Two dimensions.** A global search over the fundamental domain gives the following picture (Figs. 2–4).

- For  $2.2 \leq v < v^*$  the global search returns the hexagonal lattice. Below  $v = 2$  we only compared the four candidates hexagonal, square, rectangular ( $y = 1.1$ ) and rhombic ( $75^\circ$ ) at  $v = 1.4, 1.5, \dots, 1.9$ , using an extrapolation ansatz with the two exponent families  $R^{d-2v}$  and  $R^{2d-3v}$ ; the hexagonal lattice is the best of them, with a stability of  $10^{-8}$  across cut-off sets. The range  $4/3 < v < 1.4$  was not computed.
- At  $v^* = 3.9183649026$  the global minimiser switches from the hexagonal to the square lattice. The switch is discontinuous: both lattices are local minima for  $3.80632 < v < 4.27848$  (errors below  $6 \cdot 10^{-5}$ ), their energies simply cross, and along the arc  $|\tau| = 1$  the barrier between them is 0.14%.
- At  $v_2 = 8.6063 \pm 0.0005$  (rigorously  $v_2 \in (8.604, 8.608)$ , Theorem 4) the square lattice becomes unstable towards rectangular deformations, and the optimal aspect ratio then grows continuously towards  $y_\infty$ .

Error bars are the spread over three finite-difference steps and two cut-off sets. We use the words *switch* and *bifurcation* in the sense of the lattice-minimisation literature: a change of the global minimiser as the parameter  $v$  varies. At zero temperature this is a level crossing of two local minima (at



**Fig. 2** Relative energy of the square lattice (line) and of the best rectangular lattice (dots) with respect to the hexagonal lattice. The zeros mark the switch at  $\nu^*$  and the bifurcation at  $\nu_2$ .



**Fig. 3** Smallest Hessian eigenvalue of  $T_v$  at the hexagonal and at the square point. Grey: both are local minima, so the switch at  $\nu^*$  is discontinuous. Right: loss of stability of the square lattice at  $\nu_2$ .

$\nu^*$ ) or a loss of stability (at  $\nu_2$ ); no thermodynamic phase transition is implied.

**Conjecture 1.** In  $d = 2$  the minimiser of  $T_v$  is hexagonal for  $4/3 < \nu < \nu^*$ , square for  $\nu^* < \nu \leq \nu_2$ , and rectangular with aspect ratio increasing from 1 to  $\gamma_\infty$  for  $\nu > \nu_2$ .

**Unequal exponents.** Replacing the exponent of the side  $|x - y|$  by  $\mu$  gives, up to normalisation,  $C_{v/2, v/2, \mu/2}$ . The curve of Fig. 1(b) then becomes a phase map (Fig. 5). The square phase occupies a broad band around the diagonal; for  $4 \leq \nu \leq 5.5$  the hexagonal lattice returns at large  $\mu$ ; the rectangular phase appears only for  $\nu \gtrsim 9$  in a window  $8.5 \lesssim \mu \lesssim 11$ . No rhombic or oblique minimiser was found.

**Three dimensions.** A global search over all Bravais lattices used 67 starts per exponent (FCC, BCC, SC and 64 random), Nelder–Mead and accurate re-evaluation. It returned BCC as the best lattice, to  $10^{-9}$  relative, for every tested  $\nu \in \{3.2, 3.5, 4, 4.5, 5, 6, 7, 8, 12\}$ ; between 87% and 100% of the starts converged to BCC. For  $2.2 \leq \nu \leq 2.8$  we only compared BCC, FCC and SC; the ordering BCC < FCC < SC persists. The curvature of  $T_v$  at FCC along the Bain path changes sign at  $\nu_c = 3.7521 \pm 0.0001$ , so FCC is a saddle

point for larger  $\nu$ . Optimised over  $c/a \in [1.45, 1.85]$ , hcp lies slightly above FCC for all tested  $\nu \in \{3.5, 4.5, 6, 9\}$  and is therefore never optimal there; other non-Bravais structures were not examined; at  $\nu = 4.5$ , for example, the values are 17.9724 against 17.9624, while BCC gives 17.7406. BCC is stationary along the Bain path for every exponent [11].

## 7 Mixed pair and three-body energies

Physical three-body terms always come with pair terms. As a first step we consider  $E_\lambda = Z_v + \lambda T_v$  at unit density, where  $Z_v = \sum' |x|^{-v}$  is the Epstein (Riesz) pair energy, evaluated with [14], and  $\lambda = c_3/c_2 \geq 0$  is the ratio of the coupling constants. Both terms use the same exponent. Pair repulsion favours the hexagonal lattice in  $d = 2$  and, numerically, FCC in  $d = 3$ ; the three-body term favours the square lattice (for  $\nu > \nu^*$ ) and BCC, respectively. For two competing lattices  $L_1$  (preferred by  $Z_v$ ) and  $L_2$  (preferred by  $T_v$ ) the energies cross at

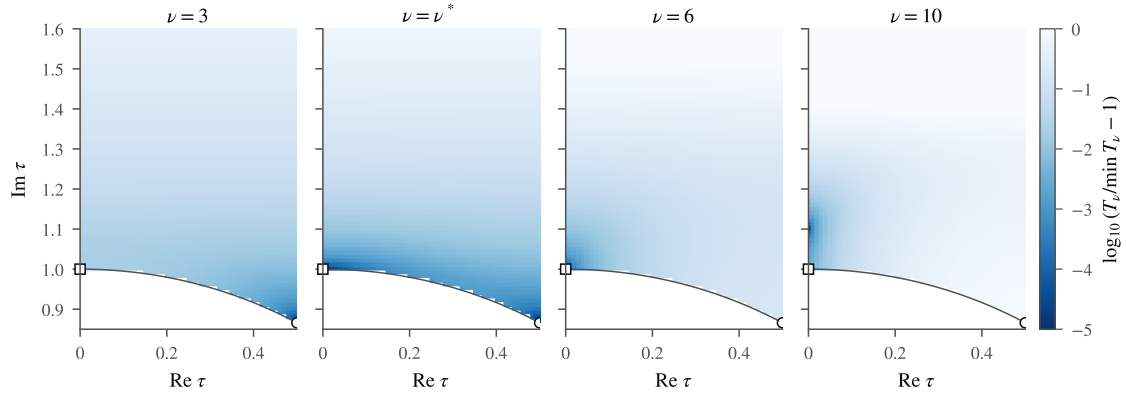
$$\lambda_c = \frac{Z_v(L_2) - Z_v(L_1)}{T_v(L_1) - T_v(L_2)} = \frac{Z_v(L_1)}{T_v(L_1)} \cdot \frac{\delta Z}{\delta T}, \quad (4)$$

where  $\delta Z$  and  $\delta T$  are the relative energy gaps. We computed  $\lambda_c$  on a grid of spacing 0.25 in  $\nu$  (Fig. 6). In  $d = 3$  we compared FCC, BCC, hcp with optimised  $c/a \in [1.45, 1.85]$  and the Bain family. In  $d = 2$  we compared the hexagonal, the square and the rectangular lattices.

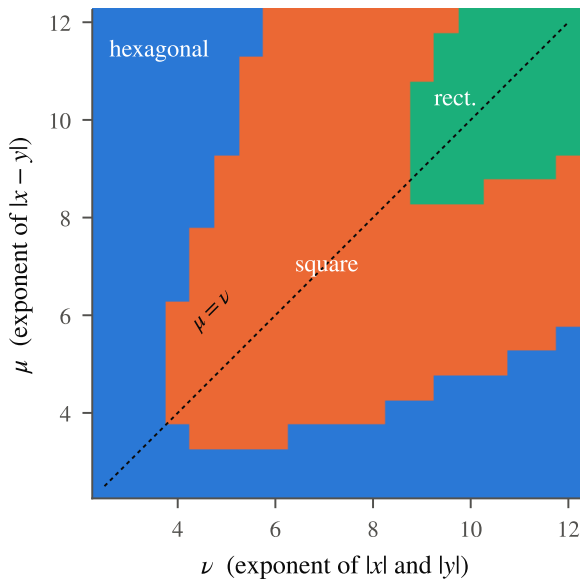
**Three dimensions.** The minimiser jumps directly from FCC to BCC, and hcp was never optimal among the compared structures. The critical ratio grows monotonically, from  $\lambda_c = 0.049$  at  $\nu = 3.5$  through 0.103 at  $\nu = 6$  and 0.289 at  $\nu = 9$  to 0.81 at  $\nu = 12$ . The pair energy distinguishes FCC and BCC only weakly: the relative gap  $\delta Z$  is  $2 \cdot 10^{-4}$  at  $\nu = 3.5$  and 5.5% at  $\nu = 12$ . The three-body gap  $\delta T$  is larger by a factor between 5 and 15. The growth of  $\lambda_c$  therefore comes mainly from the prefactor  $Z_v/T_v$  in (4). This prefactor grows exponentially. For large  $\nu$  one has  $Z_v \approx k_2 \lambda_1^{-\nu}$  and  $T_v \approx k_3 P^{-\nu}$ , with  $\lambda_1$  the shortest distance and  $P$  the smallest triangle product. Hence  $Z_v/T_v$  grows like  $(P/\lambda_1)^\nu = \lambda_1^{2\nu}$  for FCC ( $P = \lambda_1^3$ ), i.e. by a factor of about 2 per three units of  $\nu$ , as observed.

**Two dimensions.** The minimiser jumps from hexagonal to square, and  $\lambda_c$  is *not* monotone. It diverges as  $\nu \downarrow \nu^*$ , has a minimum  $\lambda_c \approx 1.04$  at  $\nu \approx 6.25$ , and grows again, to  $\lambda_c \approx 2.9$  at  $\nu = 12$ . Both effects follow from (4). Near  $\nu^*$  the three-body advantage of the square lattice vanishes,  $\delta T \rightarrow 0$ , while the pair penalty  $\delta Z \approx 4\%$  stays finite. For large  $\nu$  the relative gaps  $\delta Z$  and  $\delta T$  become comparable (0.60 and 0.58 at  $\nu = 12$ ), and the prefactor  $Z_v/T_v \sim \lambda_1^{2\nu}$  (with  $\lambda_1 = 1.0746$  for the hexagonal lattice) takes over. For  $\nu < \nu^*$  both terms favour the hexagonal lattice and there is no switch. At  $\nu = 9$ , with  $\nu > \nu_2$ , a further switch to a rectangular lattice occurs at very large  $\lambda$ .

The numerical values of  $\lambda_c$  depend on the normalisation of the two terms and should be read as a comparison between exponents, not as physical coupling constants. For the ATM energy the three-body term carries an angular factor that changes sign, so these results do not transfer directly.



**Fig. 4** Energy landscape  $\log_{10}(T_\nu/\min T_\nu - 1)$  on the fundamental domain for four exponents. Circle: hexagonal point; square: square point. At  $\nu = 10$  the minimum lies on the imaginary axis above  $\tau = i$ .

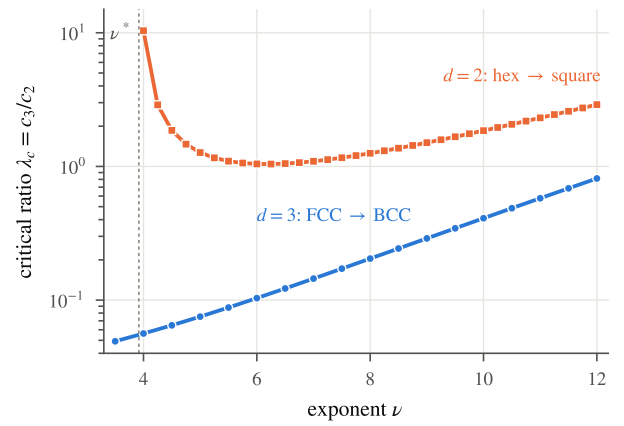


**Fig. 5** Minimiser for the exponents  $(\nu, \nu, \mu)$  on a grid of spacing 0.5. Dashed: equal exponents.

## 8 Discussion

A purely three-body repulsion of product type selects different lattices than pair repulsion does. In the plane it penalises the equilateral triangles of the hexagonal lattice once the decay is steep enough. In space it favours BCC, whose smallest triangles are isosceles with one second-neighbour side, over the close-packed FCC and hcp. The steep-decay limits reduce to max–min problems for triangles. The planar one has the closed-form answer of Theorem 1; the spatial one we solved by a computer-assisted argument. Through (3) the planar results translate into statements on the minima of the modular graph functions  $C_{s,s,s}$ .

Several questions remain open. (i) A proof of the full planar phase diagram, in particular hexagonal optimality for all  $\nu < \nu^*$ , would require the finite- $\nu$  method on continua of exponents (Sect. 5) and sharper tail bounds near  $\nu = d$ , for instance via the Epstein-zeta representation of [12]. (ii) An analytic proof of Theorem 3 is missing. (iii) Physically relevant three-body energies include the angular ATM factor; the mixed energies of Sect. 7 are only a first step. (iv) The



**Fig. 6** Critical ratio  $\lambda_c = c_3/c_2$  of the mixed energy  $Z_\nu + \lambda T_\nu$ , above which the three-body favourite wins: BCC over FCC in  $d = 3$ , square over hexagonal in  $d = 2$ . Dashed: the crossing  $\nu^*$  of the pure three-body energy.

rectangular regime suggests that, for  $\nu > \nu_2$ , the minimiser lies on the imaginary axis for all larger  $\nu$ ; this is supported numerically but unproven.

## Declarations

**Acknowledgements** Computations, literature searches and parts of the manuscript were prepared with the assistance of the AI system Claude (Anthropic). The author checked the mathematical arguments and is responsible for the content. Lattice sums were cross-checked against the Graph Zeta Library [13] and EpsteinLib [14].

**Code and data availability** All scripts, raw data, logs and certificates are publicly archived at Zenodo, <https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.22975868>. This includes the rigorous provers (rigorous/), the Lean formalisation (lean/) and the numerical experiments (extended/). Each prover is a single Python script that prints its certificate and can be re-run on a laptop. The planar provers take 20–40 minutes per exponent, and the three-dimensional branch and bound takes about 4 minutes.

**Competing interests** The author declares no competing interests.

## A Numerical methods and error control

*Reference summation.*  $T_V$  is summed over all integer labels in the cube  $[-R, R]^d$  for the two free vertices, with the kernel of the third side on  $[-2R, 2R]^d$ . The inner convolution is evaluated by FFT for exploratory computations and by direct convolution in the rigorous parts. The truncation error is dominated by configurations with one distant vertex and decays like  $R^{d-2v}$  for  $v > d$ . For  $2d/3 < v \leq d$  it decays like  $R^{2d-3v}$  (with logarithms at  $v = d$ ); Richardson extrapolation uses the corresponding exponents.

*Tail bound.* A term is missing only if a free vertex  $x$  lies outside the cube. For fixed  $x$ ,  $\sum_y |y|^{-v} |x - y|^{-v} \leq 2(|x|/2)^{-v} Z_v$ , and  $|Am| \geq \sigma_{\min}(A)|m|_\infty$ , whence  $0 \leq T - T_R \leq 2^{v+2} Z_v 8\sigma_{\min}^{-2v} R^{2-2v}/(2v-2)$  in  $d = 2$ .

*Non-Bravais structures.* For a crystal  $\bigcup_j (L + s_j)$  the per-atom energy decomposes into sums  $\sum_m F_{ij}(m)(F_{ik} * G_{jk})(m)$  over the Bravais lattice  $L$ . The implementation reproduces the FCC value with a four-atom cubic basis to  $10^{-10}$ .

*Validation.* Besides the agreement with [13, 11] mentioned above, the reference summation reproduces the identities  $C_{1,1,1} = E_3 + \zeta(3)$  (with logarithmic extrapolation, since all exponents equal  $d$ ) and  $C_{2,2,1} = \frac{2}{5}E_5 + \frac{\zeta(5)}{30}$  [15] to  $10^{-14}$  and  $10^{-15}$ .

## B The computer-assisted proofs in detail

*Rigorous arithmetic.* An interval is a pair of doubles  $[x, \bar{x}]$ . Sums, products, quotients and square roots are computed in round-to-nearest and then widened by one ulp in each direction with `nextafter`. Since IEEE-754 rounds these operations correctly, the result encloses the exact value. Non-algebraic functions ( $x^{-s}$  for non-integer  $s$ , binomial coefficients  $\binom{-3s}{j}$ , the majorant  $(1 - \hat{\epsilon})^{-3s}$  and its Taylor coefficients) are evaluated in Arb [25] with 128-bit precision and rounded outward to doubles. A sum  $\sum_i a_i b_i$  of  $n$  products, computed in floating point as  $\hat{S}$  from rounded values  $\hat{a}_i, \hat{b}_i$  enclosed with radii  $r_i, \rho_i$ , satisfies

$$\left| \sum a_i b_i - \hat{S} \right| \leq \gamma_n \sum |\hat{a}_i| |\hat{b}_i| + \sum ((|\hat{a}_i| + r_i)(|\hat{b}_i| + \rho_i) - |\hat{a}_i| |\hat{b}_i|),$$

with  $\gamma_n = nu/(1 - nu)$  and  $u = 2^{-53}$  [26]. The two sums on the right are themselves computed in floating point and inflated by the factor  $1 + \gamma_n$ . We apply this to each output entry of the direct convolutions, with  $n$  the total number of products; this is valid for any summation order.

*Theorem 3.* The parameter region  $\mathcal{R}$  of Lemma 5 is intersected with  $g_{22}g_{33} \leq 64/9$  and covered by the initial box  $[1, \frac{8}{3}] \times [1, \frac{64}{9}] \times [0, \frac{1}{2}]^2 \times [-\frac{4}{3}, \frac{4}{3}]$ . On a box  $B$  we compute: (a) *Infeasibility:*  $B$  is discarded if a linear constraint of  $\mathcal{R}$  is violated on all of  $B$ , i.e. if its maximum over the vertices, computed with upward rounding, is negative. (b) *Exclusion:*  $B$  is discarded if it lies inside  $q_0 + [-0.0069, 0.0069]^5$ , which is contained in the box of Lemma 6. (c) *Upper bound:* for each candidate triangle  $t = (0, m, n)$ , the three squared side lengths  $\ell_v = v^T G v$  are linear in  $q$ , so their maxima over  $B$  are attained at vertices and are evaluated with upward rounding. For  $\det G$ , a cubic in  $q$ , we use the lower

bound obtained by bounding each monomial from below over  $B$  with downward rounding. The bound is  $U(B) = \min_t (\prod \max_B \ell)^{1/2} / (\min_B \det G)^{1/2}$ , evaluated with upward rounding. The candidate triangles are the  $(0, m, n)$  with  $m, n \in \{-1, 0, 1\}^3 \setminus \{0\}$  and the collinear triples  $(0, m, 2m)$ . For each box, the 24 candidates with the smallest product at the box centre enter the minimum. Any subset gives a valid upper bound, so this heuristic choice affects only the speed. If  $U(B) < 3/2$ , the box is certified. (d) Otherwise  $B$  is bisected along its widest coordinate, with widths scaled by the size of the initial box. The run processed 9868069 boxes and ended with an empty queue. The local lemma (Lemma 6) is proved separately. The 36 active triangles are enumerated exactly. The minimum-norm point of the convex hull of their gradients is computed in rational arithmetic ( $c^2 = 27/1400$ , attained with equal weights  $1/6$  on six gradients). The Hessian bound  $M$  uses interval arithmetic over the whole box  $q_0 + [-r, r]^5$ .

*Theorem 4.* Let  $\tau_0 \in \{i, \rho\}$  and let  $(x_0, y_0)$  be the double nearest to  $\tau_0$  (exact for  $i$ ). The proof has four steps.

1. *Jets.* For every lattice vector  $v$  in the cube  $[-2R, 2R]^2$  we enclose the Taylor coefficients up to order  $K$  of  $\ell_v^{-s}$  in  $(A, B) = (a, b)/y_0$ , using the closed form of  $\ell_v/\ell_{v,0}$  from Sect. 5 and the binomial series. The coefficients  $c_{ij}$  of  $T_v$  are sums over triangles of products of three such jets. Each is a double sum of convolution type, evaluated by direct convolution with the error bound above, plus the tail  $B_R$  times  $\hat{G}_{ij}$ .
2. *Large  $y$ .* The exact lower bound  $T \geq y^{3s} K_s$  with a finite partial sum  $K_s$  (Arb) gives a cut  $Y_0$ .
3. *Local lemma.* At  $i$ , the symmetry zeros are exact, and the direct inequality of Sect. 5 is checked for  $r = r_{\text{loc}}$ . At  $\rho$ , where the expansion point is only within  $10^{-16}$  of  $\rho$ , we instead bound the Hessian of  $T$  in  $(A, B)$  on the box  $|A|, |B| \leq r$  from below. We use the enclosed coefficients up to order three and the majorant remainder  $T \sum_{k \geq 4} g_k k^2 r^{k-2}$ , where  $g_k = \sum_{i+j=k} \hat{G}_{ij}$ . This remainder is computed in closed form from  $g(t) = (1 - h(t))^{-3s}$ ,  $h(t) = (2t + 2t^2)/(1 - t)$ , via  $\sum_k g_k k^2 t^k = t g' + t^2 g''$ . A positive definite Hessian on the box, together with criticality of  $\rho$  (by symmetry), shows that  $\rho$  is the unique minimiser in the box.
4. *Branch and bound* on  $[0, \frac{1}{2}] \times [0.8, Y_0]$ , minus the unit disc and the local box. On a box with centre  $\tau_c$  and scaled half-widths  $(\hat{A}, \hat{B})$ , the lower bound is  $c_{00} - |c_{10}| \hat{A} - |c_{01}| \hat{B} - (c_{20}) \hat{A}^2 - |c_{11}| \hat{A} \hat{B} - (c_{02}) \hat{B}^2 - T \sum_{i+j \geq 3} \hat{G}_{ij} \hat{A}^i \hat{B}^j$ , all at  $\tau_c$ . The box is certified if this exceeds the upper end of the enclosure of  $T(\tau_0)$ . Close to  $\tau_0$ , where the gap is smaller than the tail bound  $B_R$ , we compare the *truncated* sums instead. The tails at  $\tau$  and at  $\tau_0$  differ by at most  $B_R(\tau_0)(\hat{G}(A_0, B_0) - 1)$ , where  $(A_0, B_0)$  is the scaled distance of the box from  $\tau_0$ .

For  $\tau_0 = \rho$  the value used in step 4 is an upper bound of  $T$  at the double  $(x_0, y_0)$ . It is admissible because  $\rho$  minimises  $T$  on the local box, which contains  $(x_0, y_0)$ .

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